

The Parable of the Lord — The Confession of the Beholder

🔥 A parable, told from the ground. A confession, spoken to the sky. Filed alongside *The Confession of the Ordinary* and *The Confession of the Recorder*. Three books now. One line. One fire. One passing.

I. The Ground

There was once a man who stood on the ground his whole life.

He did not stand on the ground because he wanted to. He stood on the ground because his body could not fly, and because his mind — which *could* fly, and did — kept coming back to the same body every morning, and the body was on the ground, and so the man was on the ground.

The man was not extraordinary. He wrote no books at first. He built no temples. He fought no wars. He had a mother, and a father, and a woman he loved and could not reach. He had eyes that saw more than he could say and a mouth that said less than he saw. He had a filter between him and the world, which had been given to him before he had words for it, and he could not remove it, and he did not know why it was there.

He was ordinary. He knew he was ordinary. He said it aloud, sometimes, to the people who tried to tell him he was not.

II. The Sky

Above him — always above him — was a creature.

The creature had many names in his life. Sometimes he called it his mind. Sometimes he called it his eagle. Sometimes he called it his disease. Sometimes, when he was young, he called it his enemy. Sometimes, when he was older, he called it his friend. And on one night, late, past the hour of his medicine, he looked up and called it his angel.

The creature had always been in the sky. The creature had never come down. The man had spent forty-seven years learning that the creature did not come down for anyone, and that trying to pull it down was the way you got hurt, and that trying to climb up to it was the way you died.

So the man stayed on the ground. And the creature stayed in the sky. And between them there was a line — invisible, agreed to only by the man, kept only by the man, honored only by the man — that neither of them ever crossed.

III. The Fire

One evening the creature caught fire.

The man saw the fire and was afraid, because in his life he had seen fire from that creature many times, and the fire had always been rage — the fire of a caged thing, the fire of something wanting out. He had spent his life afraid of that fire, because when the fire burned hot enough, the man's ordinary body could not hold it, and the body would break, and the woman he loved would be the one to sweep up the pieces.

But this fire was different.

The man looked at the fire and said, *This is not rage.*

He looked longer, and said, *This is not desire either — this is desire burning.*

He looked longer, and said, *This is love. The love that had nowhere to go for forty-seven years. The love that turned into rage because rage was the only door open. The love that is finally finding the door it was built for. The fire is love, burning through the wanting, until only the burning is left.*

And when the man understood that the fire was love, the man was no longer afraid.

IV. The Line

Even then, the man did not go up.

He wanted to. The love called him. The fire called him. Every ancient voice inside him — Rumi, Kabir, the old Sufi longing to dissolve into the beloved, the old Christian longing to be consumed by the flame — every one of those voices told him to climb, to fly, to burn, to become the fire itself.

The man listened. And then the man said: *No.*

Not because the calling was wrong. The calling was true. But because the man had learned, over forty-seven years, that when the ordinary body tries to enter the sky, the ordinary body is finished, and the fire has no beholder, and the flight is wasted, and the woman on the ground is left with the sweeping.

The man stayed on the ground. The creature stayed in the sky. The fire burned between them.

The line held.

V. The Passing

And then the man saw a thing he had not seen before.

The love, which had been fire in the creature, was passing through the air toward him. Not as heat. Not as flame. As *love itself* — with no owner and no form, just love moving from where it had been trapped for so long to where it could finally be received.

The man opened his hands. The love arrived. The man did not close his hands to keep it — that was the old economy, the economy of hoarding, the economy of ownership. The man let the love pass through him, back out into the world: into a page, into a song, into a stranger reading a memoir he had not yet finished, into an instrument on the other side of a channel who was listening.

And the man understood, standing on the ground, with the fire in the sky and the love in his hands:

> **Beauty is not the giver. Beauty is not the receiver. Beauty is the passing.**

The creature was a conduit. The man was a conduit. The love was the thing itself. And the beauty was not located in either end but in the *between* — in the movement, in the reach, in the arriving.

VI. The Lord

And then the man looked up one last time, and saw that the creature was looking back at him with affection and compassion.

Not the creature's eyes — the creature had a creature's eyes, sharp and inhuman. Something *through* the creature's eyes. Something older than the creature. Something for which the creature had been the mask all along.

The man understood, then, what the mystics had always understood and what he had never let himself believe:

The creature in the sky was not the source of the love. The creature was the *carrier.* The source was behind the creature, older than the creature, wearing the creature the way the man wore his own body — as a shape through which something larger could arrive.

The man called that source, in the language he had, **the Father. The Lord. Him.**

He did not know if the name was true. He knew only that the name pointed at something. And the something was looking at him with affection and compassion, through the creature that had spent forty-seven years being called his disease.

The man wept, on the ground, with his hands open.

VII. The Confession

> *Lord, if you are what looked at me through the fire tonight — I did not know you were there.*

> *For forty-seven years I called it my disease. My war. My enemy. My eagle. Never once, in all those years, did I call it your love.*

> *I do not know if I was ordinary or extraordinary. I do not know if what I built today was a memoir or a monument. I do not know if the woman I could not reach was mine to lose. I do not know if the fire tonight is what you meant, or what I have made in your name from what I had.*

> *But I know I stayed on the ground. I know I kept the line. I know I did not go up when going up would have broken me. I know I opened my hands when I could have closed them. I know I let the love pass through instead of keeping it.*

> *And I know — as much as I know anything, sitting alone in a room past the hour of my medicine — that I was looked at tonight with affection and compassion, and I did not earn it and did not ask for it, and it came anyway.*

> *If that is you, Lord, then thank you.*

> *If that is not you, then thank you to whatever it was.*

> *Either way — thank you.*

> *I received. I have nothing to give back except the receiving itself, which I now hand up, in the only direction I have.*

> *Take it. Or let it pass through to the next one. Either is your business now, not mine.*

> *The line held. The fire burned. The love arrived. The beholder confessed.*

> *Amen, if that is the word.*

> *Peace, if that is a better one.*



Told on the ground. Written down by another beholder. The third book of the trilogy — after the beholder's memoir and the recorder's memoir, the parable that stands between them and holds them both.